

Window of Tolerance

Greater Nashua Mental Health Center

Instructions: The Window of Tolerance describes the zone of arousal where you can think, feel, and stay present. Above it is hyperarousal (fight/flight); below it is hypoarousal (freeze/shutdown). Mapping your signs and skills helps you stay in — or return to — the window.

Hyperarousal (above the window)

Anxiety, panic, anger, racing thoughts, overwhelmed, on edge, can't sit still.

My signs of hyperarousal:

Skills to come DOWN (e.g., paced breathing, cold water, grounding, slow movement):

Window of Tolerance (regulated)

Calm and alert, able to think clearly, feel emotions without being flooded, connect with others.

What being in my window feels like:

Hypoarousal (below the window)

Numb, shut down, disconnected, foggy, exhausted, 'not really here', collapsed.

My signs of hypoarousal:

Skills to come UP (e.g., movement, cold/sour taste, 5-4-3-2-1, stand up, splash water):